

Cattails

Harvesting, drying & preparing for weaving

Cattail leaves make a beautiful, soft weaving material. A little care while harvesting, drying, and rehydrating them will help keep the leaves long, strong, and flexible.

Harvesting

WHERE TO HARVEST

My preference is to harvest cattails from roadsides rather than wetlands. Wetlands provide important food, shelter, and nesting material for wildlife, so I leave those plants where they are.

A healthy roadside patch can be harvested year after year.

AS YOU HARVEST

- ☐ Cut the leaves above the water level to encourage plant health.
 - ☐ Leave plants with seed heads standing.
 - ☐ Keep the leaves as straight as possible. Try not to bend, fold, or kink them while harvesting or transporting them. A kink creates a weak point that may tear later when you weave.
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At home

1 **Separate**

Pull the leaves apart so air can reach every surface.

2 **Dry**

OUTDOORS

If the weather will be hot and dry, spread the leaves on a concrete pad or plastic tarp, only one or two leaves thick.

INDOORS

Lean the leaves against a wall in light layers with plenty of airflow. I usually place them near an air vent or point a fan toward them.

3 **Check daily**

Jostle and rearrange the leaves each day so they dry evenly.

After a couple of days, or just a few hours in really hot weather, the tips should be starting to feel crispy while the leaves are still flexible enough to bend without cracking.

4 **Bundle**

Gather an armful of cattails together. Fold the tips over and tie the top of the bundle.

If you have been drying them outdoors, bring the bundle inside to finish drying completely before storing.

Before you weave

4 hours before weaving, rehydrate your dried cattails by getting them thoroughly wet, then wrapping them in a damp cloth and plastic

OUTDOORS

Give the cattails a thorough shower with a hose or watering can. Jostle the leaves as you go to make sure water gets between them.

INDOORS

Put the leaves in the shower, give them a very quick dunk in the bathtub, or mist them thoroughly with a spray bottle.

Wrap them up and let the moisture work its way through the leaves for about 4 hours.

Taking a break

If you need to take a break while weaving, you have two options.

Keep everything damp

Wrap your cattails and project back up in the damp cloth and plastic and put them in the freezer. For a short break, I have been known to put a small project in the fridge for an afternoon.

Let everything dry

Allow your cattails and project to dry completely, then rehydrate them again when you are ready to continue.

The important thing is not to leave damp cattails sitting wrapped up at room temperature.

Cattails in Alberta

NATIVE

Broad-leaved or common cattail

Typha latifolia

We have one native cattail species in Alberta.

INVASIVE

Narrow-leaved cattail

Typha angustifolia

If you are harvesting narrow-leaved cattail, take extra care not to spread it. Leave the seed heads at the site and do your best to keep seeds or other plant material from travelling with you.

FIND A CATTAIL PATCH

Both species have been recorded on iNaturalist. Search *Typha latifolia* or *Typha angustifolia*, then zoom the map into your area to see observations near you.

[INATURALIST.ORG](https://www.inaturalist.org) →

Half Moon Baskets

WE GATHER. WE WEAVE. WE CARRY SOMETHING HOME.